

DELHI While the nation remains glued to the Gandhi scion, the other Rahul has to put up an almighty struggle to stay in the limelight. And that too for the right reasons. After allegations of drug abuse—an ongoing case which has put his political career on pause—and a divorce, the late Pramod Mahajan's son is back. Rahul Mahajan's new quest is the lofty search for intelligent life on the planet and elsewhere in the solar system.

Mahajan is in talks with the California-based Search for Extra-Terrestrial Intelligence (SETI) Institute, the sky-searchers who scan the heavens with radio telescopes for traces of alien life. He aims to start an India chapter of the organisation. Borrowing liberally from famous US astronomer Carl Sagan, he says confidently, "We can't be the only ones in the universe, it would be

Sci-fi Scion

SPACE CADET:
Rahul Mahajan



an awful waste of space."

To be called the SETI India Research Foundation, the national chapter will function like the US-based non-profit group founded in 1984. "It won't be about finding little green men on Mars

as much as firing the spirit of scientific enquiry within the country," says Mahajan, who recalls trips with his father to the Lonar crater near Aurangabad as "inspirational".

SETI's India chapter will fund science projects

within the country and will study the Lonar crater. "We want people to fund science in India," Mahajan says. He cites Sagan's sci-fi novel *Contact* as a key motivator. Then, a personal visit to Mumbai two months ago by SETI founder, the legendary Dr Frank Drake, and current SETI director Dr Jill Tartar (the inspiration behind the Jodie Foster character in *Contact*), came as something akin to an extra-terrestrial visitation for this aspiring politico. The trio discussed the idea of an India chapter, setting up a huge radio-telescope, programmes like 'adopt a scientist' and a series of documentaries to be produced by Mahajan's media production house Ambitious. But with sister Poonam taking on his father's political career, it is obvious that Mahajan has had to fall back on his scientific temper.

by Sandeep Unnithan

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The Ministry of Fertilisers and Chemicals has spun out a new Department of Pharmaceuticals with a secretary and the attendant bureaucracy. So much for Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's call to cut down on wasteful expenditure.

VOICES



"There is no instability in the Government and politics in the country. If there is any instability, it is in the mind of the leader of the Opposition."

Manish Tiwary, Congress spokesperson

"The Congress has insulted Samajwadi Party earlier. Now for the third consecutive time, Samajwadi Party wants to be insulted. The Congress will insult them again."

Om Prakash Chautala, Indian National Lok Dal chief

"We have to be careful of those elements who have one leg in India and the other across the border. They are more dangerous as they are not loyal to any country."

Ghulam Nabi Azad, outgoing Jammu & Kashmir chief minister

"My father (former actor and MP Sunil Dutt) walked a different path. Let me put it this way. If my father decided to walk, I took a bike."

Priya Dutt, Congress MP

"Films are made by stories, not by stars. The one thing we lack is good scripts."

Yash Chopra, filmmaker

